

THREE

‘Whose photograph is that?’ Hema asked as she buried her face inside my wide-open suitcase. Our beds were adjacent to each other inside the barracks and we had been asked to share the same luggage shelf.

‘My father’s photograph from his academy days,’ I replied as I unpacked.

‘He’s in the army?’ Hema asked. I nodded. I still hadn’t informed Papaji that I had cleared the screening test.

‘Why do you keep it?’ a curious Hema asked.

‘The same reason you keep your mother’s old watch in your bag,’ I replied.

‘You noticed? How do you know it’s my mother’s?’ a startled Hema asked.

‘My mother had a similar one almost a decade ago. Besides, you kept it in your bag. You fear losing it and you don’t wear it. So it’s definitely not just a fashion statement,’ I reasoned.

‘That’s *sakkath* [awesome],’ she exclaimed, playfully hitting me.

It was half past eight and many of the girls who hadn’t made it had already left for the railway station or the bus stand. Those who had made reservations for the next day were given a separate barracks, while the rest of us who were to stay on for the next five days were allotted eleven ten-bed barracks, their doors facing a square veranda, which had two badminton courts in each half of the square. The walls along the corridor were lined